Coaching vs App Recommendations in IntelliCare: Effects on Depression, Anxiety & Engagement

Modular mobile apps for depression and anxiety

Mohr et al., 2019, Journal of Medical Internet Research

What was done?

Mohr et al., 2019

- Participants: 301 adults
- Design: 8-week 2 × 2 factorial RCT
  - Coaching vs self-guided
  - Weekly app recommendations vs no recommendations
- Follow-up: 6 months post-treatment
- Outcome measures: PHQ-9 (Patient Health Questionnaire-9), GAD-7 (Generalized Anxiety Disorder-7), app use (time to last use, sessions, apps downloaded)

Technology: IntelliCare Platform

1. 12 simple apps:
   - Single strategies: goal setting, behavioral activation, sleep hygiene, relaxation, emotion regulation, cognitive restructuring, etc.
   - Most uses < 30 seconds
2. Hub app:
   - Central notifications
   - Weekly recommendations (tray notification → suggested app → app store)
3. Recommendation engine:
   - Based on ~100,000 users' usage data
   - Suggests apps likely to be used

Mohr et al., 2019

Main Results

- Median time to last use during treatment: 56 days (of 56)
- Median sessions during treatment: 216 (~3.9/day)
- Post-treatment: 84% continued using apps, median 92 days, 83 sessions
- Recommendations → more sessions (232 vs 202; P = .04)
- Coaching → more apps downloaded (11 vs 7; P < .001)

key highlights

HQ-9 and GAD-7: strong reductions in all groups

Coaching → better anxiety outcomes

Recommendations → better depression outcomes

Mohr et al., 2019

Why it is relevant & special

This study is relevant because it addresses two big issues in digital mental health:

1. Poor engagement: most mental health apps are abandoned quickly.
2. How to support users: should we use human coaching, automated recommendations, or both?

Mohr et al., 2019

thank you